

How SWE hiring actually works

Week 1, Lecture 1 · Landing the Offer: SWE Job Search for Senior CS Students

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- The four stages every applicant moves through
- Where applicants get cut, and why
- The side doors that exist at every stage
- Where your time goes and whether that allocation is right
- Lead time: why timing matters more than effort alone

Part 1: the hiring funnel

Four stages, four filters

- **Stage 1: application screen** - resume + keyword filter, often automated
- **Stage 2: recruiter screen** - 15-30 minute phone call to confirm fit and interest
- **Stage 3: technical interviews** - coding rounds, system design, sometimes a take-home
- **Stage 4: offer and close** - team fit, leveling, compensation negotiation

Each stage cuts a large fraction of candidates. Knowing the cut rate at each stage tells you where preparation time pays off most.

Where applicants die

- Most applications die at stage 1: the resume never reaches a human
- Recruiter screens cut on communication, role fit, and location mismatches
- Technical rounds cut the largest absolute number: this is where prep has the highest return
- Offer stage cuts are rare but real: leveling mismatches and competing timelines

The implication: fixing a bad resume is faster than grinding 200 more LeetCode problems if your resume is the bottleneck.

The stage 1 problem

- Online portals receive hundreds of applications per role
- ATS (applicant tracking systems) filter on keywords before a human reads anything
- A resume that passes ATS and passes a 30-second human read is doing two different jobs
- Most resumes fail one or both

Orosz (2020): "Many tech interview preparation books almost exclusively focus on the coding side of things... this is far from enough."

Part 2: the side doors

The formal funnel is not the only path

- The formal funnel (portal application) is the one everyone uses
- Side doors exist at every stage and convert at much higher rates
- Luu (2015): companies compete for the same small pool of trendy candidates; candidates who bypass this competition win

The side doors are not cheating. They are what experienced engineers use by default.

Side doors at stage 1: bypass the ATS entirely

- **Referral:** a current employee submits your resume directly to a recruiter
- **Prior intern:** companies fast-track return intern candidates; conversion rates above 70% at many firms
- **Open-source contributor:** your commit history on a project the company uses is a public resume
- **Cold introduction:** a well-crafted message to an engineering manager who has seen your work

A referred resume is reviewed; an unrefered portal application may not be.

Side doors at stage 3: signal before the interview

- **Prior public work:** a blog post, demo, or write-up a hiring manager finds before you apply
- **Find-a-problem:** identify a real issue at the company, build a small solution, surface it to the right person
- **Unpaid stint:** two weeks of focused work at a company that lets you in the door

These paths do not skip the technical bar. They change the prior: the interviewer already has a positive signal before the first question.

Why side doors matter for new grads specifically

- New grads have thin formal credentials: no work history outside internships
- The formal funnel weights credentials heavily at stage 1
- Side doors shift the filter: your work replaces your credentials
- Orosz (2025): "Junior developers can't get hired not because there are no jobs, but because companies are raising the bar for what 'junior' means."

The students who land roles are the ones who demonstrate they can operate with less hand-holding.

Part 3: time and lead time

Where your time actually goes

- Most candidates underestimate the elapsed calendar time of a search
- Application to offer at a large company: 6-12 weeks minimum
- University recruiting at large tech companies: applications open in August for the following May graduation
- Missing an application window by two weeks can mean waiting a full year

The lead time math

- Graduating May 2027: large-company applications open August 2026
- That is 9 months before graduation and 2 months from now
- Mid-size companies: applications open October-January, offers by February
- Startups: rolling, but the best roles fill fast once posted

If you are reading this in October and have not started, you are already late for some windows. That is recoverable, but only if you act this week.

If your type is the same type everyone else is competing for, you are competing for talent with the wealthiest companies in the market.

<footer>Dan Luu, "We only hire the trendiest," 2015</footer>

Take-aways

1. The hiring funnel has four stages: application screen, recruiter screen, technical interviews, and offer close. Each has a different cut mechanism.
2. Most candidates die at stage 1 because their resume never reaches a human. Fix the bottleneck at your current stage before adding volume.
3. Side doors exist at every stage and convert at higher rates than portal applications. Referrals, prior public work, and open-source contributions all bypass the ATS.
4. Lead time is real. Large-company recruiting windows open months before graduation. Missing a window means waiting a year.

What's next

- **Reading:** Week 1 reading covers the full funnel, side-door taxonomy, and how to build your target list (read before section)
- **Lecture 2 (this week):** The new-grad pipeline, university recruiting calendar, and target list construction
- **Section (this week):** Target-company-list workshop: build 30+ rows with tier and side-door tags
- **HW 1 (out this week):** Resume and portfolio audit, due Week 3